

07

VPN and Remote Access

VPN will not connect, remote desktop, remote work access and certificate issues

Default priority: P3 Medium
(P2 if many remote users affected)

Target response / resolution: Respond in 15 min / resolve in 2 business hours

Handled by: Tier 1, then Tier 2 / Network

Scope

Use this instruction when a user working remotely cannot connect to the VPN or reach internal resources.

Related instructions: WI-06 Network, WI-10 Security Incidents, WI-01 Password Reset

Common symptoms

- VPN client fails to connect, or disconnects often
- Connected to the VPN but cannot reach internal sites or file shares
- Remote desktop session refused or very slow
- Certificate or MFA errors at VPN sign-in

Information to collect

- Location and type of home network (home broadband, mobile hotspot, public Wi-Fi)
- VPN client name and version, and the exact error text
- Whether the user can reach the internet and cloud apps without the VPN
- Time of the last successful connection

Resolution steps

- 1 Confirm internet access.** Verify the user has a working internet connection without the VPN. Restart the home router if needed, and test on another network.
- 2 Check the account.** Confirm the account is active, not locked, and in the VPN access group. Check MFA registration and look for failed sign-in attempts in the logs.
- 3 Check the VPN client.** Confirm the client version is current and the profile is correct. Restart the client, then reinstall it if the fault continues.
- 4 Check the device.** Confirm the date and time are correct, the device certificate is valid, and the device is compliant with security policy.
- 5 Rule out local blocks.** Look for personal firewalls, third-party antivirus, or a router that blocks the VPN ports. Try another network to compare.
- 6 Fix access after connecting.** If connected but unable to reach resources, flush DNS, check the assigned VPN IP and routes, and confirm the target service is reachable from the internal network.
- 7 Verify and document.** Have the user open an internal application and a file share. Share the VPN quick guide and how to report slowness.

Escalate when

- VPN gateway or authentication service errors, or many users failing at once
- Account shows sign-ins from unusual locations (see WI-10)
- Access requested to a restricted network segment (needs approval)

Resolution and closure

- Record the cause (client, account, network, policy) and the fix
- Close after the user confirms they can work over the VPN

Quick troubleshooting reference

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
VPN fails to connect at all	Account issue, no internet, or blocked port	Check the internet without VPN, confirm the account and MFA, and try another network.
VPN connects then drops	Weak home Wi-Fi, ISP issue, or idle timeout	Use wired or a closer position, update the client, and review gateway logs.
Connected but no internal access	DNS or routing problem, or the app is down	Flush DNS, check the assigned IP and routes, and test the service from inside the network.
Certificate error	Expired or missing device certificate	Check the device is enrolled and compliant, and renew the certificate.
Very slow over VPN	Home bandwidth, full tunnel, or gateway load	Run a speed test, close heavy apps, and check gateway utilization.

Suggested wording for the user

Open	"Are you able to browse the internet without the VPN? That tells me if the problem is your home connection."
During	"I am checking that your account and device are cleared for remote access. This may take a few minutes."
Close	"You are connected. If it fails again, tell me the time and the error text so I can find it in our logs."

Good practice

Do

- Confirm internet works without VPN first
- Check device compliance and certificate
- Collect error text and time
- Share the VPN quick guide

Do not

- Do not disable security tools to get VPN working
- Do not give out shared VPN credentials
- Do not open firewall ports for a single user
- Do not ignore sign-ins from unusual locations

Worked example

A remote user connects to the VPN but cannot open the file share.

Ticket note field	Entry
Issue reported	VPN shows connected, but \\fileserver is unreachable.
Checks performed	Ping to the file server's IP works. Name lookup fails.
Cause	VPN client not using the internal DNS servers.
Action taken	Flushed DNS and reinstalled the VPN profile with the correct DNS settings.
Result	File share opens. Closed after user confirmation.

Analyst checklist

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Confirm internet access | ☐ Fix access after connecting |
| ☐ Check the account | ☐ Verify and document |
| ☐ Check the VPN client | ☐ Ticket note completed using the standard template |
| ☐ Check the device | ☐ User confirmed the issue is resolved |
| ☐ Rule out local blocks | |

Preventing repeat tickets

- Keep the VPN client updated through the endpoint tool
- Monitor gateway capacity
- Publish a home-network checklist
- Review VPN access groups every quarter